WHAT TO DO IF YOU ARE HAVING A HEART ATTACK

1 Do not ignore warning signs such as extreme fatigue, chest pain, breathlessness, dizziness or pain in your arms

2 Do not drive, call an ambulance or get someone nearby to drive you. It is important to get to the hospital as soon as possible so that blood flow to the heart can be restored and damage to the muscle minimised

3 If the person is alert and breathing, then there is no need for CPR or cardiopulmonary resuscitation; it is better to rush the person to the hospital instead

4 CPR should be given if the person is unconscious. Call an ambulance too in the meanwhile. CPR uses rhythmic chest compressions to mimic how the heart pumps, and keep the blood flowing

5 To prevent blood clots, take aspirin (which is available under the brand names of Ecosprin, Sprin, Aspro, Eprin and Delisprin). Painkillers too can be given for chest pain. If you can call a doctor, take further advice based directly on the situation



"If you have pain lasting more than a few minutes, rush to a doctor. Continuous pain is not a good sign. If not a heart condition, it could mean something else"

DR VINAY KUMAR BAHL
Principal Director, Cardiac Sciences, Max Healthcare

on the day of his death, but had self-medicated on antacids, mistaking it to be a case of indigestion. However, like any heart attack, a silent one, too, is characterised by a blockage in the flow of blood to the heart, damaging the heart muscle.

A variety of studies indicate that the burden of cardiovascular disease, particularly heart attacks, has become far more common amongst younger people. The 'Indian Hearts Lacking Care (IHL Care) Study' by wellness company India Health Link (IHL), in collaboration with social advocacy group HEAL Foundation, found that 53 per cent of Indians in the 26-to-40-year age group are at high risk of cardiovascular disease due to two pathologies—obesity and hypertension. The survey was conducted among 1,461 respondents in Mumbai, Delhi, Bengaluru and Chennai. Another study, conducted over two years, found that 35 per cent of the 2,200 patients it surveyed had their first cardiac event when they were less than 35. The study, titled 'First Attack Survey', was done by the government-run Sri Jayadeva Institute of Cardiovascular Sciences in Bengaluru. "Sedentary lifestyles, smoking, pollution and junk food consumption are rising in a country that is already genetically more prone to heart attacks than Americans or Europeans," says Devi Shetty, chairman of Narayana Healthcare. Add to the genetic predisposition sustained poor nutrition, little exercise, high blood pressure, high blood sugar and high cholesterol, and the risk goes up manifold, and at a far younger age.

Trouble is, few people realise they have a problem till it hits them. As Dr Ashok Seth, chairman of the Fortis Escorts Heart Institute, observes, "People don't account for all the hidden risk factors they might have, such as lifestyle, pollution, family history, blood sugar, hypertension. Around 25 per cent of coronary artery disease



"Sedentary lifestyles, smoking, pollution and junk food consumption are rising in a country already genetically prone to more heart attacks than the West"

DR DEVI SHETTY
Chairman, Narayana Healthcare

doesn't show up as symptoms, and usually people believe unless they have a major symptom or unless routine blood tests show something, they don't need to assess other risk factors."

WATCH WHAT YOU EAT

It all starts with the food we eat, say experts. The WHO recommends no more than 16-22 gm of saturated fats and 6 gm of salt in a day. As for free sugars, it says daily intake must be less than 10 per cent of our total energy intake and ideally 5 per cent or roughly 25 gm or 6 teaspoons. Yet nutritional data available on the websites of most popular fast food chains in India throw up surprising revelations. A Paneer Tikka wrap at Subway, for example, has 15 gm of saturated fats, even more than some of its non-vegetarian cousins typically associated with this type of fat, and a